

Drafting the American Borders: Internal Supremacy and External Fortitude (1816–1824)

How the Era of Good Feelings forced a young United States to define its constitutional limits, regional identities, and hemispheric power.



The Paradox of the Era of Good Feelings

The Facade of Unity



In 1816, Democratic Republican James Monroe easily defeated Federalist Rufus King, signaling the collapse of the Federalist party.



As the last Revolutionary War officer to become President, the 60-year-old Monroe brought old-fashioned manners and an intense speaking style.



His 1817 goodwill tour sparked enthusiastic cheers even in Boston—a former Federalist stronghold.

The Reality of Fracture



The Reality of Fracture

- Beneath the surface, the nation was splitting into distinct regional identities.
- Citizens increasingly identified not as Americans, but as northerners, southerners, or westerners.

Post-War Market Dynamics Threaten American American Industry

Step 1: Unregulated Currency

The 1st National Bank charter expired in 1811. State banks issued too much money, causing rapid inflation and instability.

Step 2: The Industrial Head Start

The Embargo Act and War of 1812 had allowed leaders like Francis Cabot Lowell to build American mills. But British factories were older, their machines already paid off.

Step 3: Predatory Dumping

Post-1815, British manufacturers poured cheap goods into the U.S., sometimes selling cloth below cost to bankrupt American rivals and capture the market.

Step 4: The Breaking Point

Dozens of New England businesses failed, forcing Congress to act to protect domestic industry.

The Tariff of 1816 Ignites Sectional Resentment

To block British goods, Congress passed a highly protective tariff. The economic impacts immediately splintered along regional lines.

The North (Winners)

- **Economy:** Manufacturing base.
- **Impact:** Foreign goods became excessively expensive, making American goods highly competitive.
- **Result:** Factories sold more products; regional wealth and business growth surged.

The South & West (Losers)

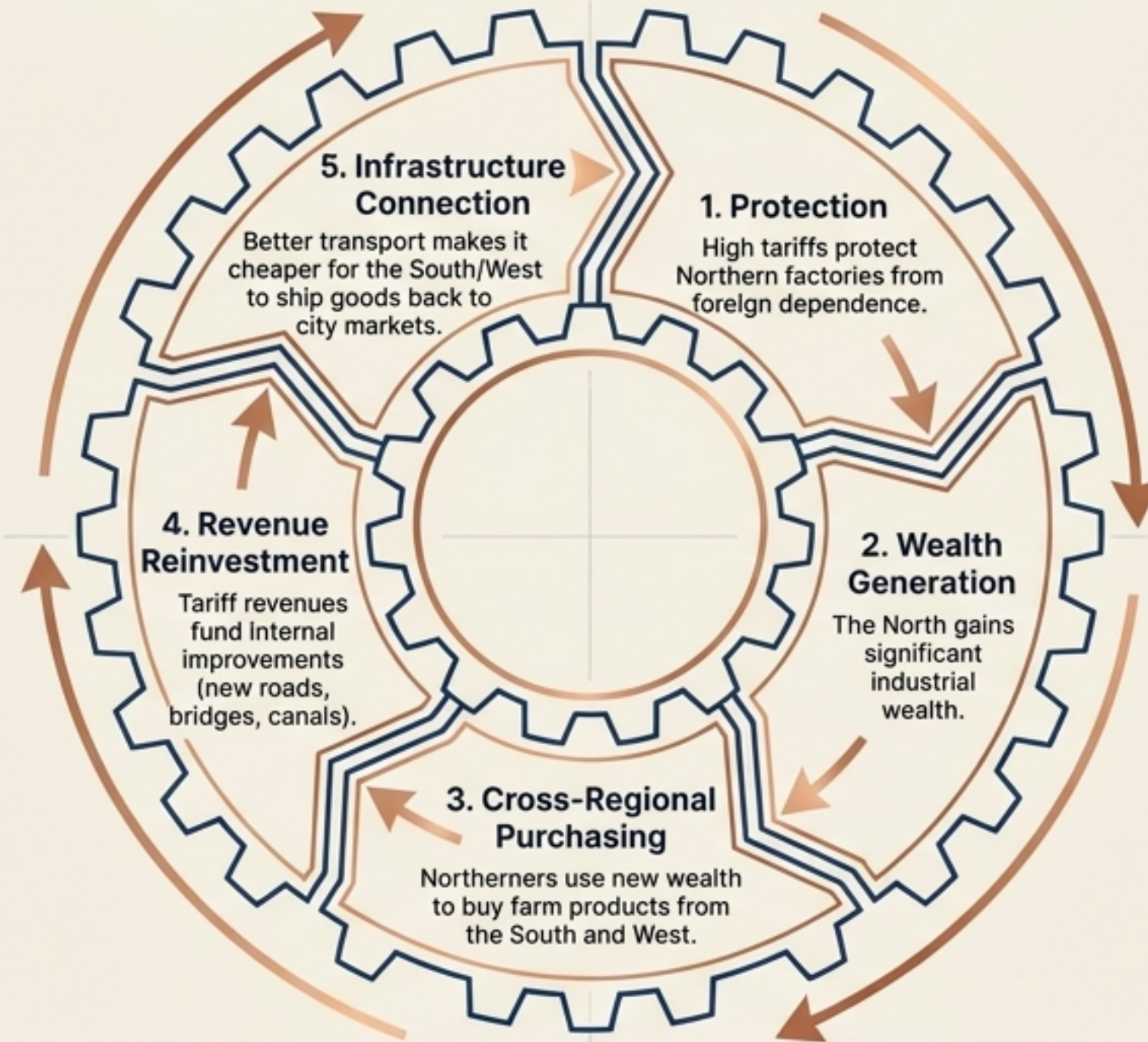
- **Economy:** Farming base (heavily reliant on imported goods).
- **Impact:** Prices for everyday goods like cloth and iron skyrocketed.
- **Result:** Southerners complained the tariff made northern manufacturers rich entirely at their expense.

Three Voices Compete to Define the National Identity

The Voices of Sectionalism Matrix

Leader	Core Region	Federal & Economic Stance	Stance on Slavery
 John C. Calhoun	The South	Opposed policies that strengthened central government power. Opposed tariffs that hurt southern consumers.	Firm defender of the institution.
 Daniel Webster	The North (New Hampshire). Known as a great cannon loaded to the lips.	Favored a larger federal role in building the economy. Supported tariffs to protect New England industry.	Believed the institution was evil.
 Henry Clay	The West (Kentucky). Known as Gallant Harry of the West.	Strongly favored active central government. Promoted the American System to benefit all sections.	(Compromiser)

Henry Clay's American System Attempts to Engineer Unity



The Roadblock

The system never fully engaged. Southerners hated paying for roads they didn't need (relying on fine rivers instead), and strict constructionists argued federal infrastructure spending was unconstitutional.

The Supreme Court Cements Federal Supremacy over the States

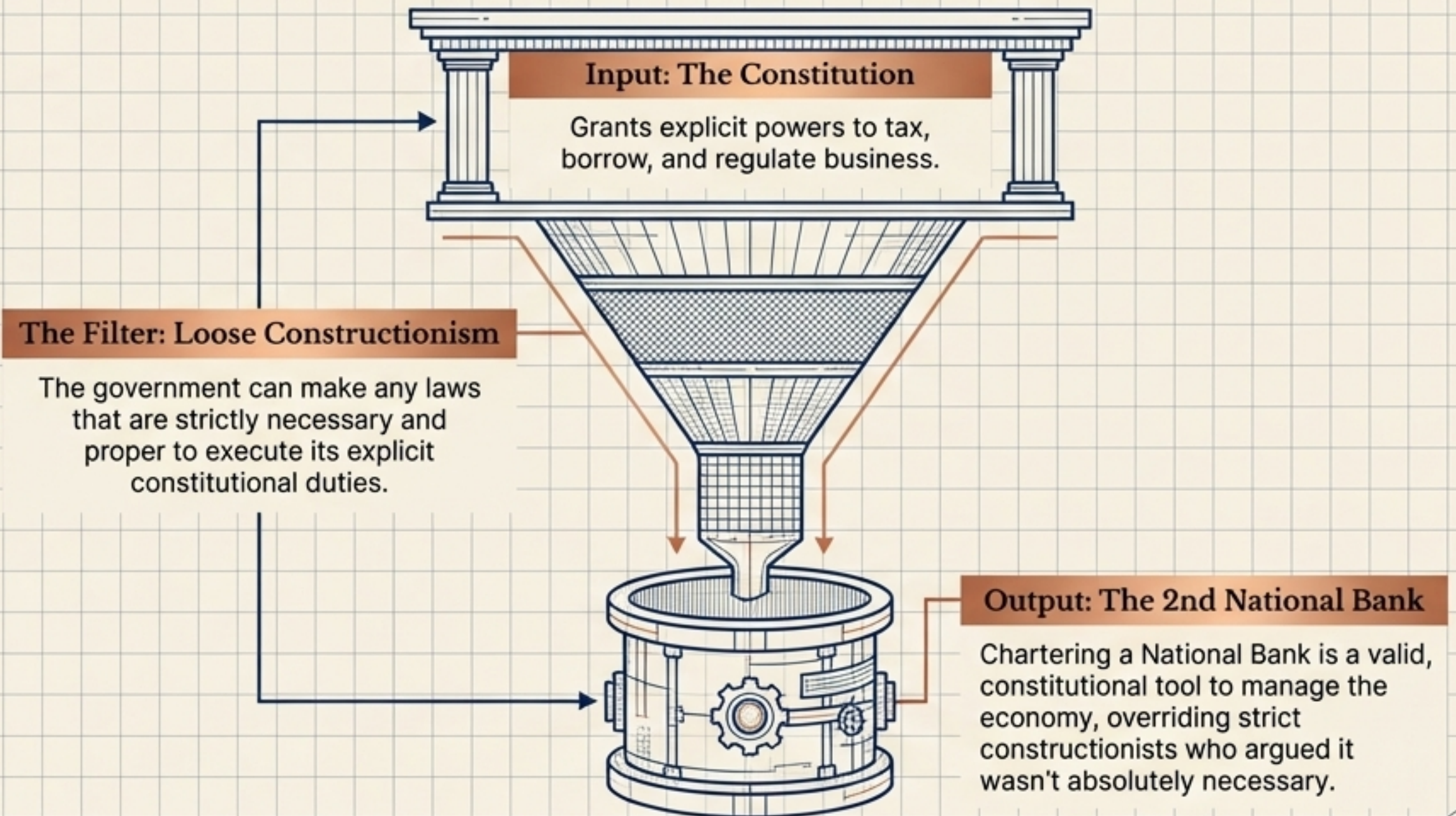
The Context

In 1819, Maryland attempted to tax the 2nd Bank of the United States. Cashier James McCulloch refused to pay.

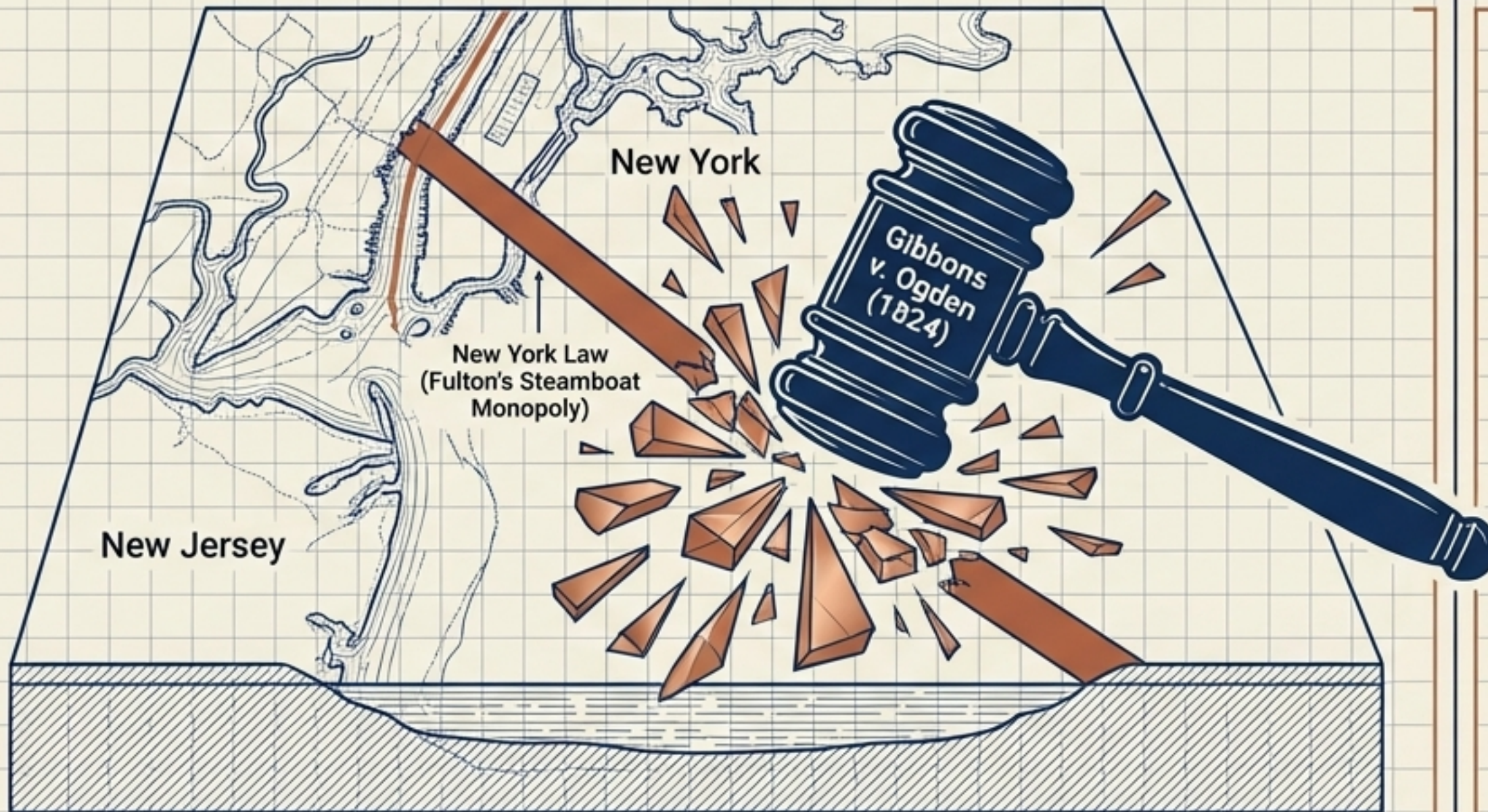
The Ruling (McCulloch v. Maryland)

Chief Justice John Marshall ruled that states have no right to interfere with federal institutions within their borders.

The Necessary & Proper Legal Funnel



Breaking State Monopolies to Build a National Market



The Ruling: The Supreme Court struck down the state monopoly, declaring that a state can only regulate trade within its own borders.

The Real-World Impact

Federal Authority

Established that only the federal government can regulate interstate commerce.

Consumer Benefit

Destroyed Fulton's monopoly, allowing competitors to enter the market and drastically lowering passenger fares.

Economic Scale

Created a single, predictable national market, making it infinitely easier to do business nationwide.

The Spanish Empire Retreats from the Western Hemisphere

Mexico (1821): Sparked by priests Miguel Hidalgo and José Morelos. Creoles eventually formed a republic.

Central America: Declared independence in 1821, forming the United Provinces of Central America by 1823.

Argentina, Chile, Peru: José de San Martín led southern liberation campaigns starting in 1816.

Republic of Great Colombia (1819): Simón Bolívar (The Liberator) led an army over the high Andes to defeat Spanish forces.

Brazil (1822): Portuguese colony won peaceful independence under Prince Pedro.

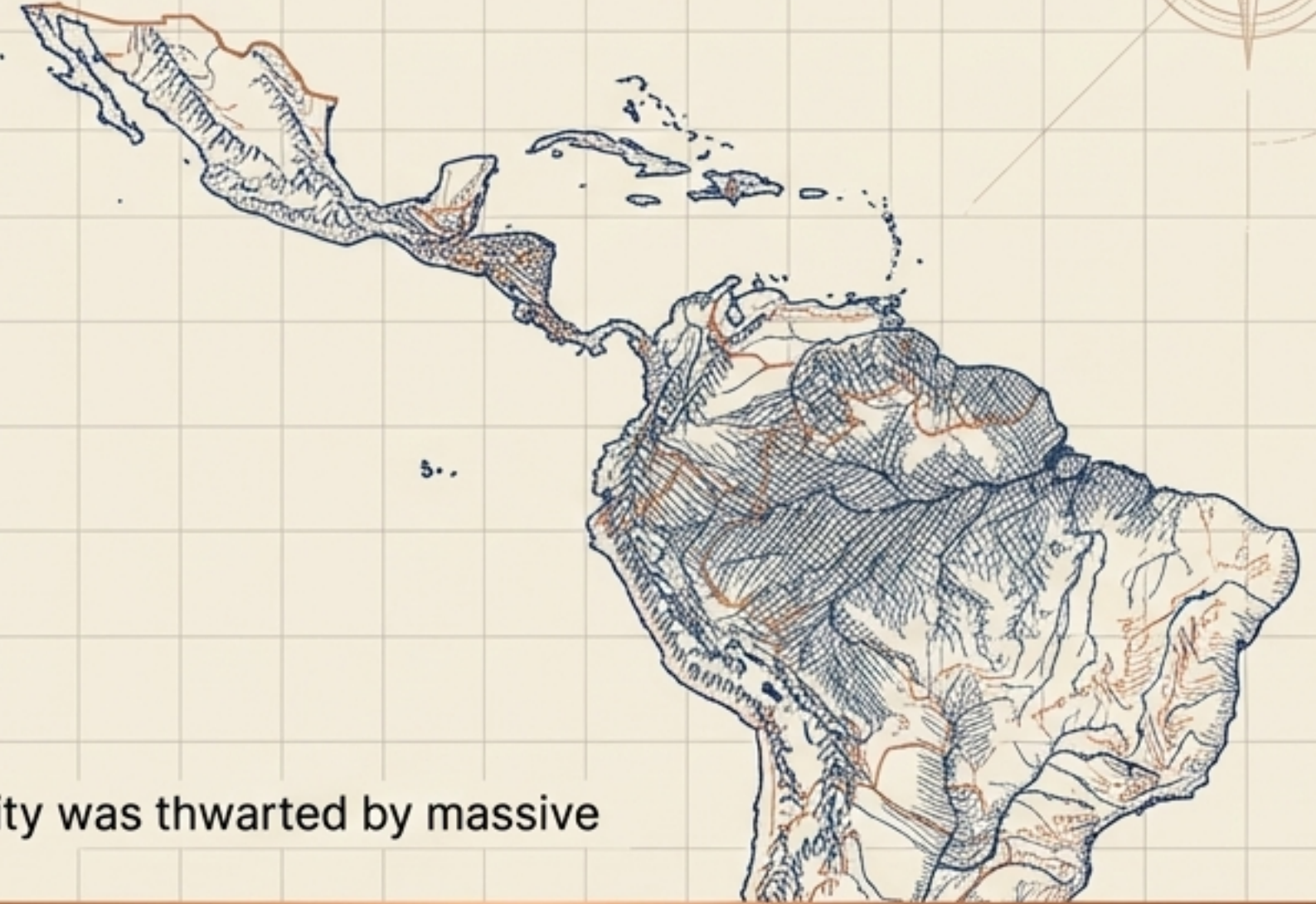
Key Insight: By 1825, Spain had lost all Western Hemisphere colonies except Puerto Rico and Cuba.

Why Latin America Did Not Form a Single Union

The Expectation: Spain's former colonies modeled their new constitutions directly on the United States. However, the reality of unification was vastly different.



The 13 U.S. colonies were geographically compact and deeply experienced in local self-governance before independence.



Latin American unity was thwarted by massive barriers:

- 1. Geographic Isolation:** The sheer immense size of the territory, combined with thick rainforests and the rugged Andes mountains, acted as impenetrable barriers to travel and communication.
- 2. The Governance Vacuum:** Under Spanish rule, colonists gained almost no experience in self-government. Powerful leaders quickly seized control during post-revolutionary turmoil, destabilizing early democratic attempts.

Securing the Southern Border: The Acquisition of Florida

The Threat

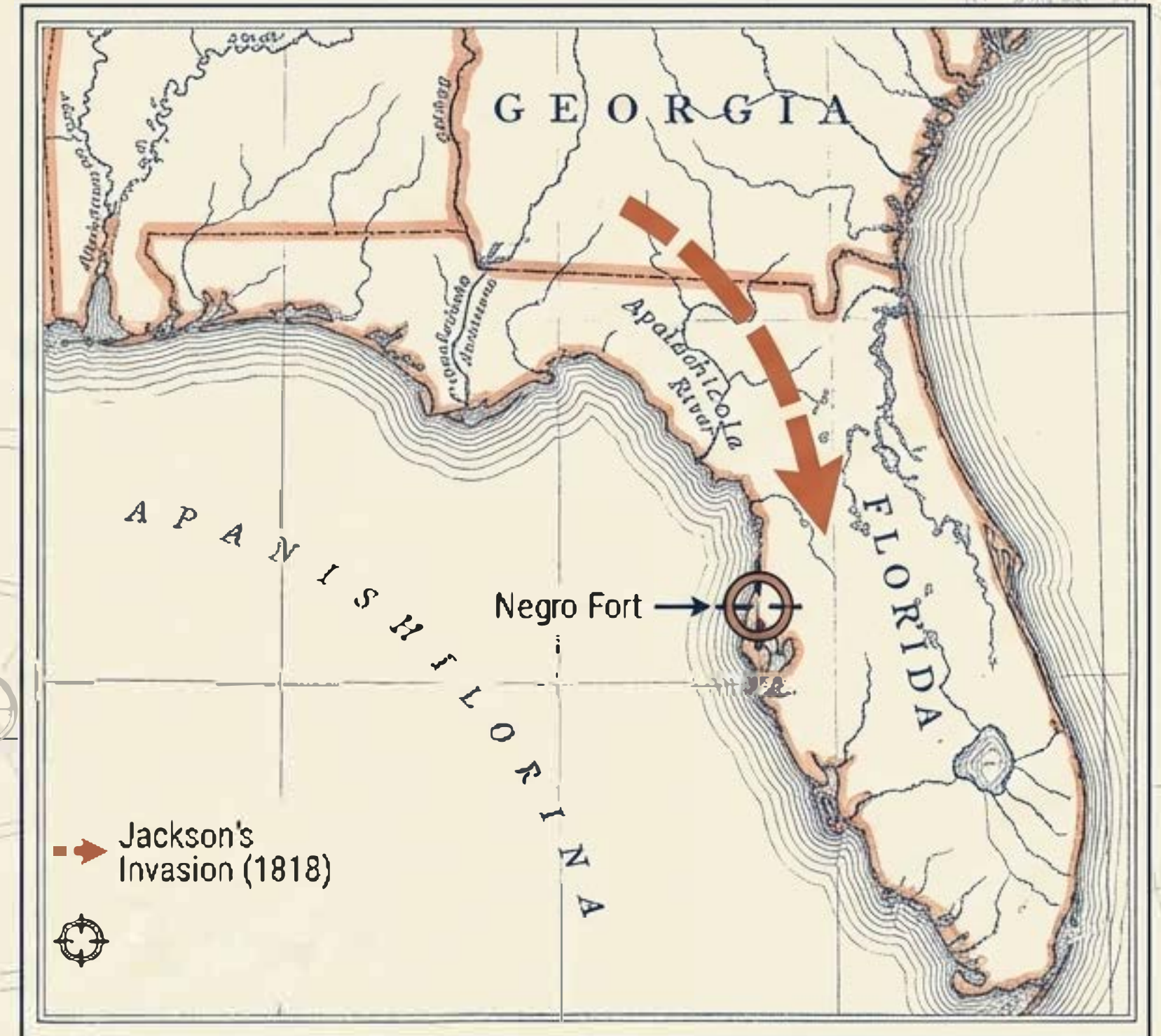
White southerners worried about Creeks and Seminoles raiding Georgia settlements from Spanish Florida. Florida also served as a refuge for black Seminoles (escaped enslaved Africans).

The Aggression

General Andrew Jackson demanded Spain demolish the **Negro Fort**. When Spain refused, U.S. forces invaded and destroyed it. In 1818, Jackson invaded again with over 3,000 soldiers.

The Resolution

Preoccupied with Latin American rebellions, Spain could not risk a war. Secretary of State John Quincy Adams negotiated the Adams-Onís Treaty (effective 1821), purchasing Florida for \$5 million.



A Looming European Threat Forces a Bold Declaration

The European Alliance

In 1815, Prussia, France, Russia, and Austria formed an alliance to crush revolutions. They appeared ready to help Spain forcibly retake its Latin American colonies.

The Pacific Threat

Russia aggressively claimed lands along the Pacific coast of North America.

The British Proposal

Fearing the loss of highly profitable trade, Britain suggested a joint U.S.-British statement guaranteeing the freedom of the new Latin American republics.

Monroe's Pivot: Secretary of State Adams and President Monroe rejected a joint statement, deciding the United States must assert its own independent authority on the world stage.

The Monroe Doctrine: Drawing a Line in the Atlantic

The 1823 Declaration

No New Colonies

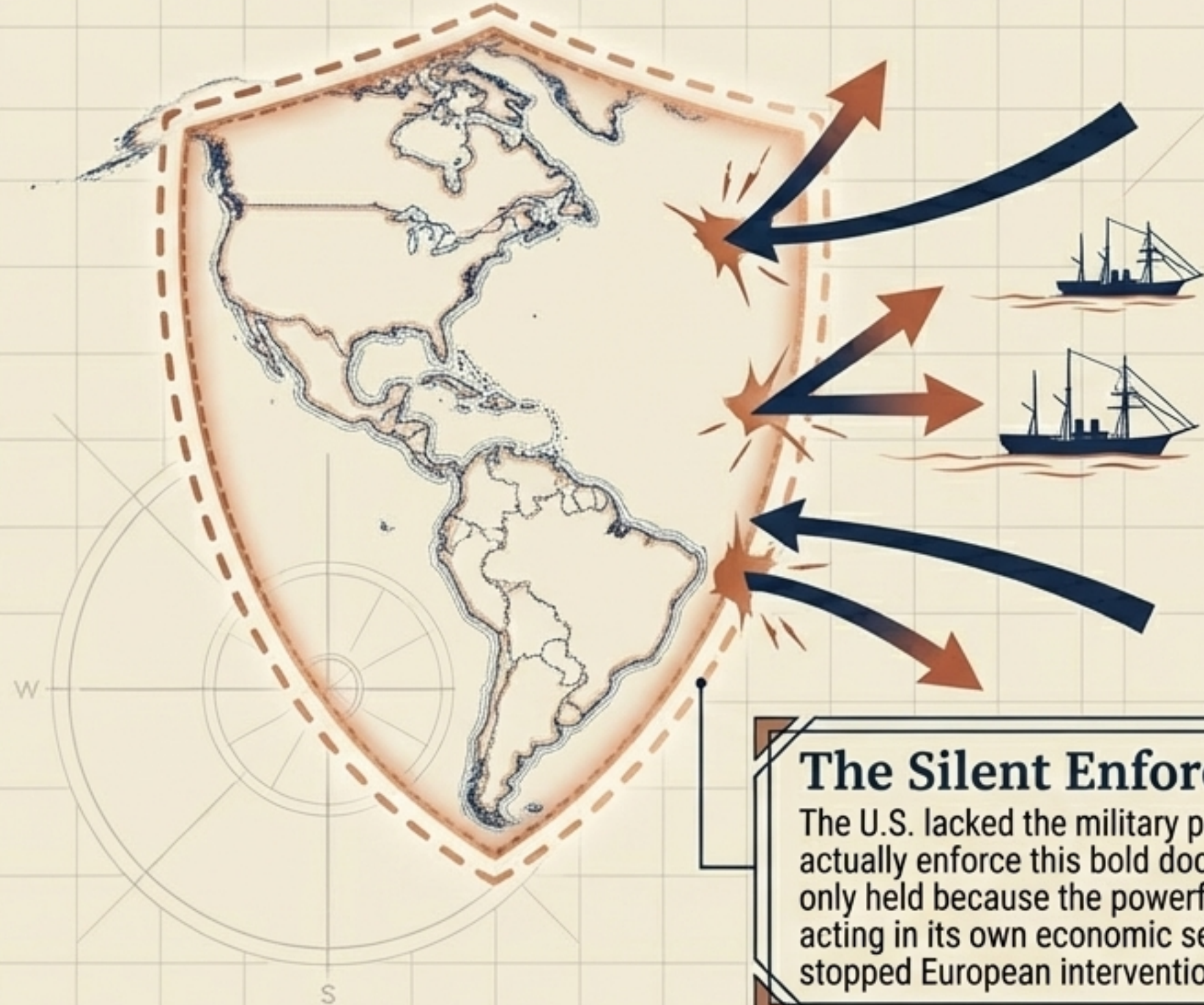
The U.S. will oppose any European attempt to build new colonies in the Americas.

No Reconquest

The U.S. will oppose any attempt to reclaim old, newly independent colonies.

No Interference

In exchange, the U.S. will not interfere in the internal affairs of European nations or their existing colonies.



The Silent Enforcer

The U.S. lacked the military power to actually enforce this bold doctrine. The shield only held because the powerful British Navy, acting in its own economic self-interest, stopped European intervention.

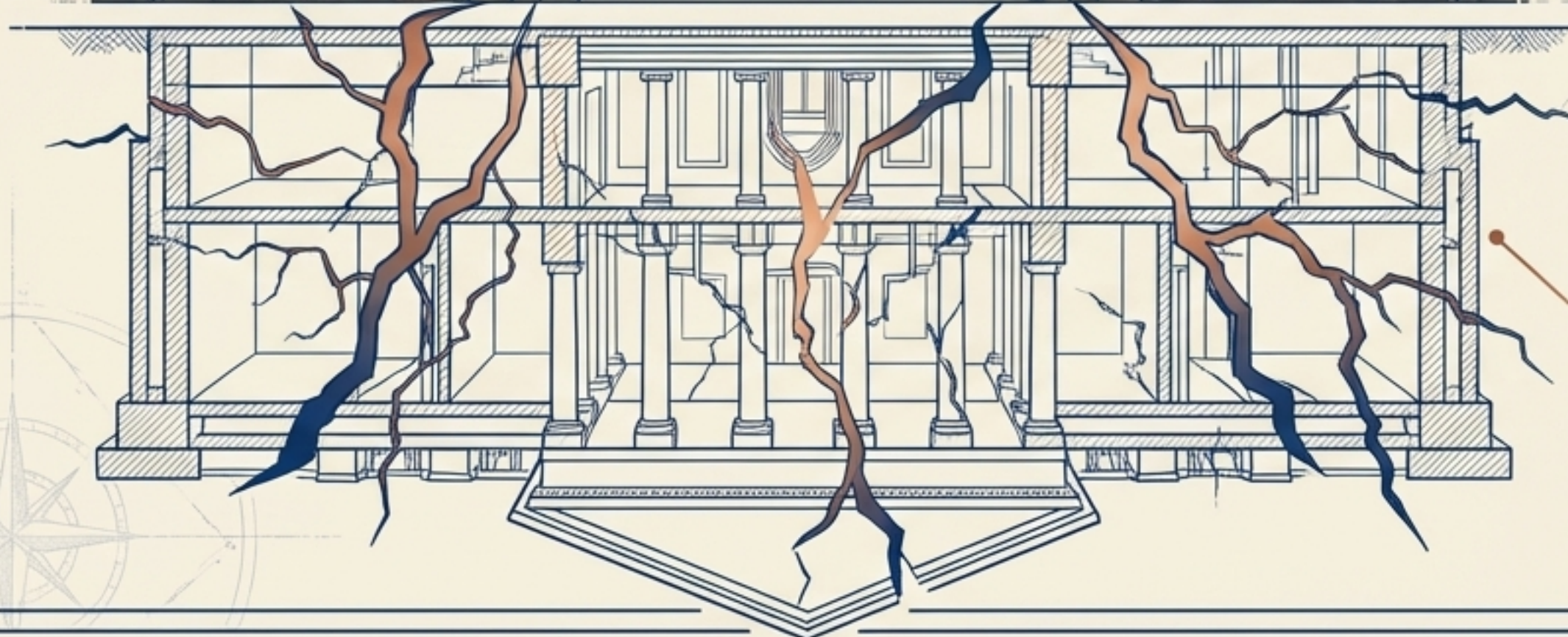
The Dual Legacy of the Monroe Era

The Era of Good Feelings was the crucible that forged the architecture of the modern United States—outwardly impenetrable, yet inwardly deeply divided.



External Fortitude (The Facade)

- **Physical borders secured** (Florida acquired via Adams-Onís).
- **Ideological borders drawn** (Monroe Doctrine sets foreign policy for the next century).



Internal Consolidation (The Foundation)

- **Federal supremacy** cemented in law (McCulloch, Gibbons), overriding state monopolies.
- Yet, the failure to fully implement Clay's American System left the North, South, and West economically at odds—setting the stage for catastrophic sectional crises.